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Air Products owns and operates a large industrial gas complex



PHOTO BY ARUN SAHA

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“Don’t change to meet expectations”

What was the problem you were grappling with?

When I started working, I was juggling a career and a family at the same time. I had a typical superwoman syndrome, where I aspired to be perfect in every role and wanted to hold myself to the highest standards. I was usually the only woman in the room, and I was often worried about perceptions and being accepted. Back then, we had limited diversity and very few role models to help us out.

Whom did you approach for advice, and why?

I had a diverse group of mentors, within and outside the industry, who understood my own aspirations and capabilities and helped put things in the right perspective.

What was the advice you received?

One of the best pieces of advice I received was: ‘In order to be successful, one need not change who they are to fit the circumstances or meet expectations, even if you are the only woman in the room or have a different experience than everyone else.’ I was told it is more important to bring your true, authentic self to the table and to not try to do everything. Surround

yourself with smart, capable, creative people you can trust and lean on in situations where you feel overwhelmed. One must be open to listening from everyone on the team.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

Thanks to my mentors, I learnt to worry less about what other people think. I learnt to seek out thoughtful and productive feedback and ignore the naysayers. And regarding being the only woman in the room, I learnt to embrace the difference and use it as an advantage. The advice helped me grow and flourish in my professional and in my personal life too. **BT**

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